Citizen Feedback Driving Public Service Reform in Uganda

Date: 4 Mach 2026

Who We Are

SEMA is an award winning Ugandan civic technology and social enterprise founded in 2028.Our mission amplify citizens voices and drive evidence-based reform across East Africa's public institutions, from police stations and health centers to municipal ofices.We operate at the intersection of technology, governance, and human rights, using accessible feedback tools to bridge the gap citizens and the institutions that serve them.

Our Impact at Glance

100,000 +
Citizens Reached

26
Partner Offices

192+
Data Reports

80%
Wait Time Reduction

62%
Satisfaction Increase

3
Feedback Channels

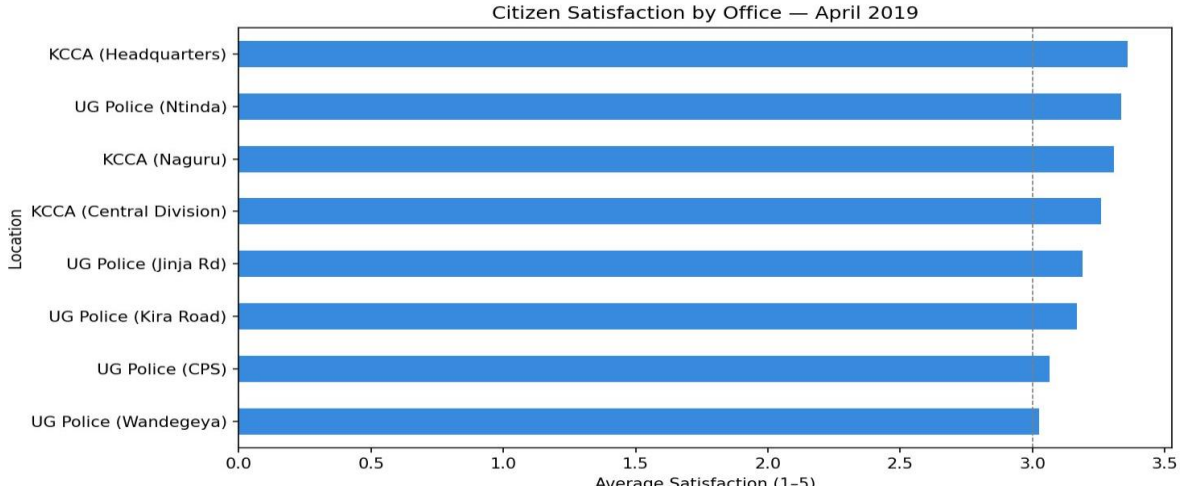
SDG 16.6
UN Goal Aligned

2018
Year Founded

We collaborate formally with the Uganda Police (Justice Law and Order Sector) and the Kampala Capital City Authority (KCCA), and our work is directly aligned with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 16.6: building accountable and transparent institutions at all levels.

April 2019 Survey-Key Findings

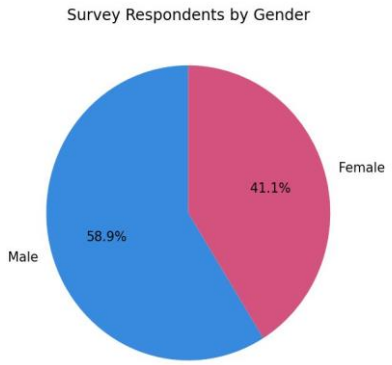
In April 2019, SEMA collected 1,106 in-person citizen feedback responses across 8 Kampala public offices, 5 Uganda Polices Stations and 3 KCCA services centres.The data reveals a system in transition Satisfaction scores across all offices cluster around the neutral midpoint (3/5), signaling real room for improvement and confirming the value of SEMA's ongoing presence.



Citizen Satisfaction by Officer

KCCA Headquarters led all offices with an average satisfaction score of 3.35/5.UG Police (Wandegeya) scored lowest at 3.05/5-all 8 offices sit above the neutral midpoint of 3, reflecting baseline of adequate service delivery.

April 2029 Survey-continued

Satisfaction vs. Wait Time	Who We Heard From
	
Citizens who waited under 15 minutes recorded higher satisfaction across all offices. This confirms that reducing queue times is one of the most actionable levers for improving citizen experience	**58.9% male, 41.1% female respondents. 65% were aged 30–50. SEMA's own longitudinal data shows women wait longer and are less likely to receive resolutions — making gender-disaggregated tracking essential.**

Corruption Monitoring

33	3%	97%
Corruption Incidents Reported	**Overall Corruption Rate**	**Respondents Reported No Corruption**

While only 3% of respondents reported a corruption incident in April 2019, SEMA's historical data (n=9,762, 2018) shows that nearly 40% of Ugandans have paid a bribe to access public services at some point (Transparency International, 2018). SEMA's real-time, anonymous reporting system provides one of the few reliable mechanisms for tracking corruption at the point of service.

How SEMA Creates Change

Listen: Citizens submit anonymous feedback via IoT smiley-face devices, USSD codes, toll-free IVR phone lines, WhatsApp surveys, and face-to-face interviews, accessible to all, regardless of literacy or internet access.

Analyse: Each office receives a monthly data report with infographics showing satisfaction scores, wait times, corruption rates, and citizen suggestions , translated into actionable, digestible insights.

Act: SEMA field teams conduct unannounced visits, facilitate community forums (Barazas), and hold stakeholder meetings at HQ level to push for evidence-based reform.

Improve: The feedback loop results in documented improvements: cleaner station environments, shorter queues, fewer bribery incidents, and in one case, a national police budget revision to supply food rations to detained suspects.

Broader Impact & Looking Ahead

Beyond individual offices, SEMA's data influences national policy. Our research surfaced that Uganda's Fourth Justice Sector Development Plan (SDP-IV) contained no concrete anti-corruption mechanisms at the service level, a gap SEMA's reports have directly addressed. The new SDP-V now lists 'satisfaction with front-end justice services' as a primary outcome indicator.

SEMA's Big Hairy Audacious Goal: by 2030, all public service providers in East Africa will use citizen feedback to improve their service delivery. With over 100,000 citizens already heard, 26 offices engaged, and partnerships with Uganda's Ministry of Justice and KCCA, SEMA is building the infrastructure for a more accountable East Africa, one feedback response at a time.

References

Primary Data Sources

- SEMA Citizen Feedback Survey, April 2019. Raw dataset: April_2019_excel_sheet_exercise__1_.xlsx (n=1,106 responses across 8 Kampala public offices). Cleaned and analysed by Charles Daniel Apollo: sema_cleaned.csv / sema.db.

SEMA Organisational Sources

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- SEMA Uganda. (2022). Citizen Engagement — Jinja Recap: Feedback Matters Campaign. Medium. Retrieved April 2026. https://medium.com/@info_74530/citizen-engagement-jinja-recap-c15a35fdb9d2
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Third-Party Sources Cited Within SEMA Reporting

- Transparency International. (2018). Corruption Perceptions Index. Statistic: approximately 40% of Ugandans reported paying bribes to access a public service.
- HiiL. (2016). Justice Needs and Satisfaction in Uganda. Finding: citizens generally do not trust formal service providers to resolve justice problems compared to informal providers.
- Republic of Uganda. (2015). Second National Development Plan (NDP II). 'Poor public sector management' identified as the country's most binding constraint to development.
- Justice Law and Order Sector Uganda. (2018). Strategic Development Plan IV (SDP-IV). Cited for absence of concrete anti-corruption mechanisms at the public service level despite core mission mandate.
- Justice Law and Order Sector Uganda. (2020). Strategic Development Plan V (SDP-V). 'Satisfaction with front-end justice services' added as a primary outcome indicator — informed by SEMA data.
- United Nations. Sustainable Development Goal 16.6. 'Develop effective, accountable and transparent institutions at all levels.' https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal16

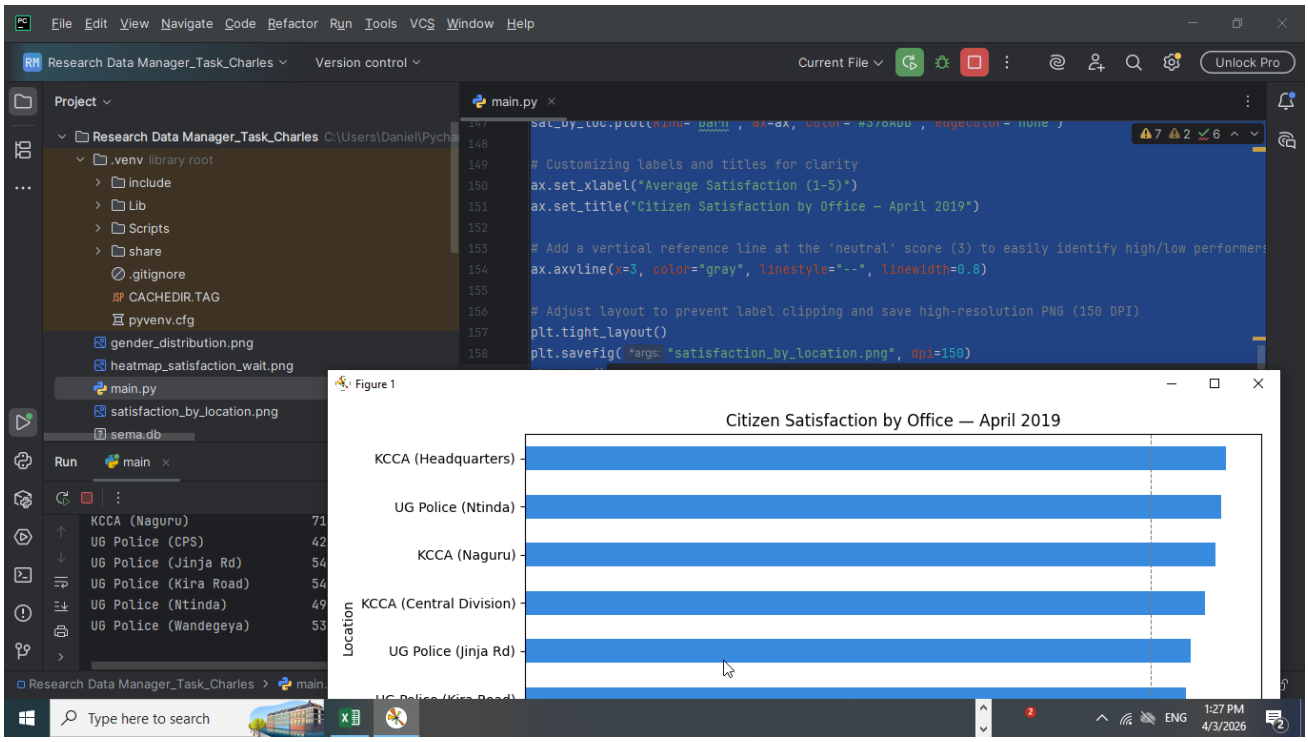
Annexes and Supporting Screenshots

Tools Used for the Assignment

- Python – Served as the primary programming language for data processing, analysis, and visualization throughout the assignment.
- Claude AI – Utilized to review the code, assist me with debugging, and provided guidance on improving the structure and efficiency of the scripts.
- PyCharm – Used as the integrated development environment (IDE) for coding, including data loading, cleaning, analysis, and visualization tasks.
- SQL with Python (SQLite) – Applied for loading the cleaned dataset into a database and performing basic data manipulation and storage operations.

Python Libraries Used/Loaded into the environment for Task execution.

- pandas – Used to read Excel and CSV files, perform data cleaning, transformation, and exploratory data analysis.
- openpyxl – Used by pandas as the engine to read and process .xlsx Excel files.
- matplotlib and seaborn – Used to create data visualizations such as bar charts, pie charts, and heatmaps for analytical insights.
- sqlalchemy – Enabled interaction between pandas and the SQLite database for storing and querying the cleaned dataset.



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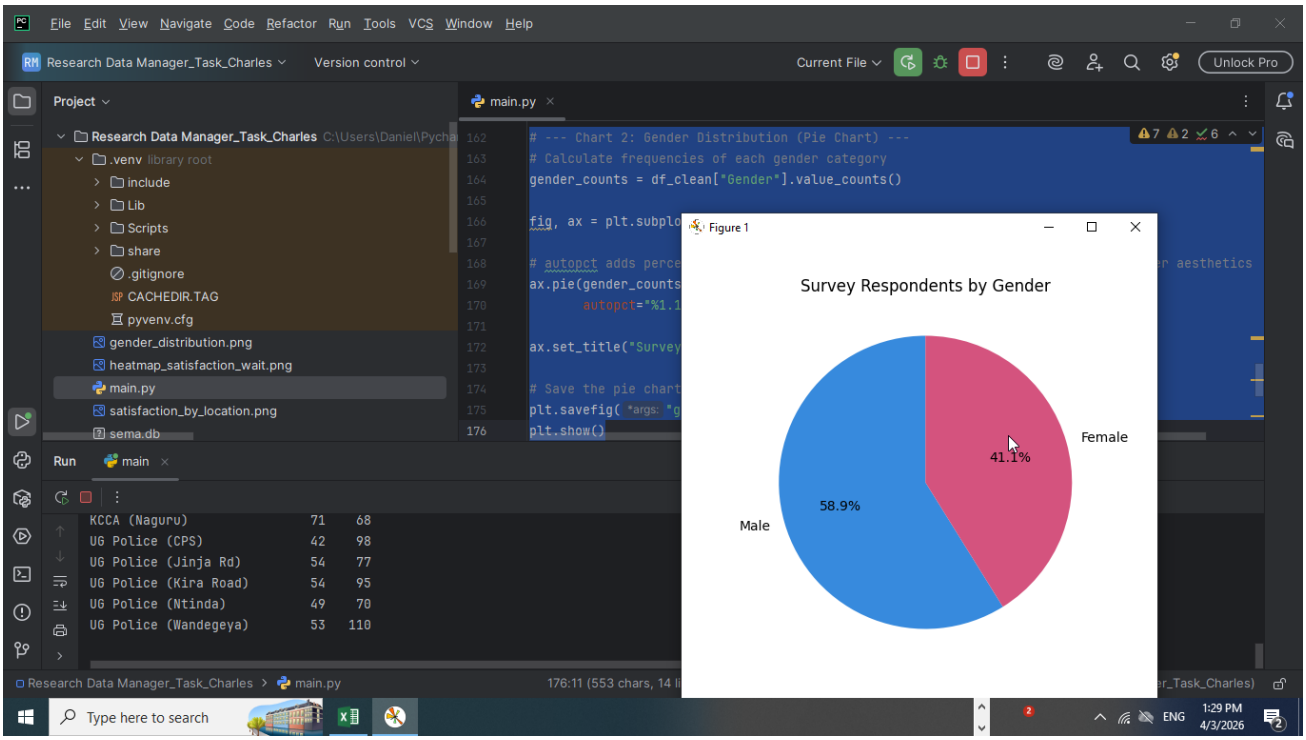
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gender_distribution.png
heatmap_satisfaction_wait.png
main.py
satisfaction_by_location.png
sema.db
# --- Chart 2: Gender Distribution (Pie Chart) ---
# Calculate frequencies of each gender category
gender_counts = df_clean["Gender"].value_counts()
fig, ax = plt.subplo
autopct adds perce
ax.pie(gender_counts
autopct="%1.1
ax.set_title("Survey
Save the pie chart
plt.savefig(*args: "g
plt.show()
Figure 1
Survey Respondents by Gender
Female
41.1%
58.9%
Male
Run
main
KCCA (Naguru) 71 68
UG Police (CPS) 42 98
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UG Police (Ntinda) 49 70
UG Police (Wandegeya) 53 110
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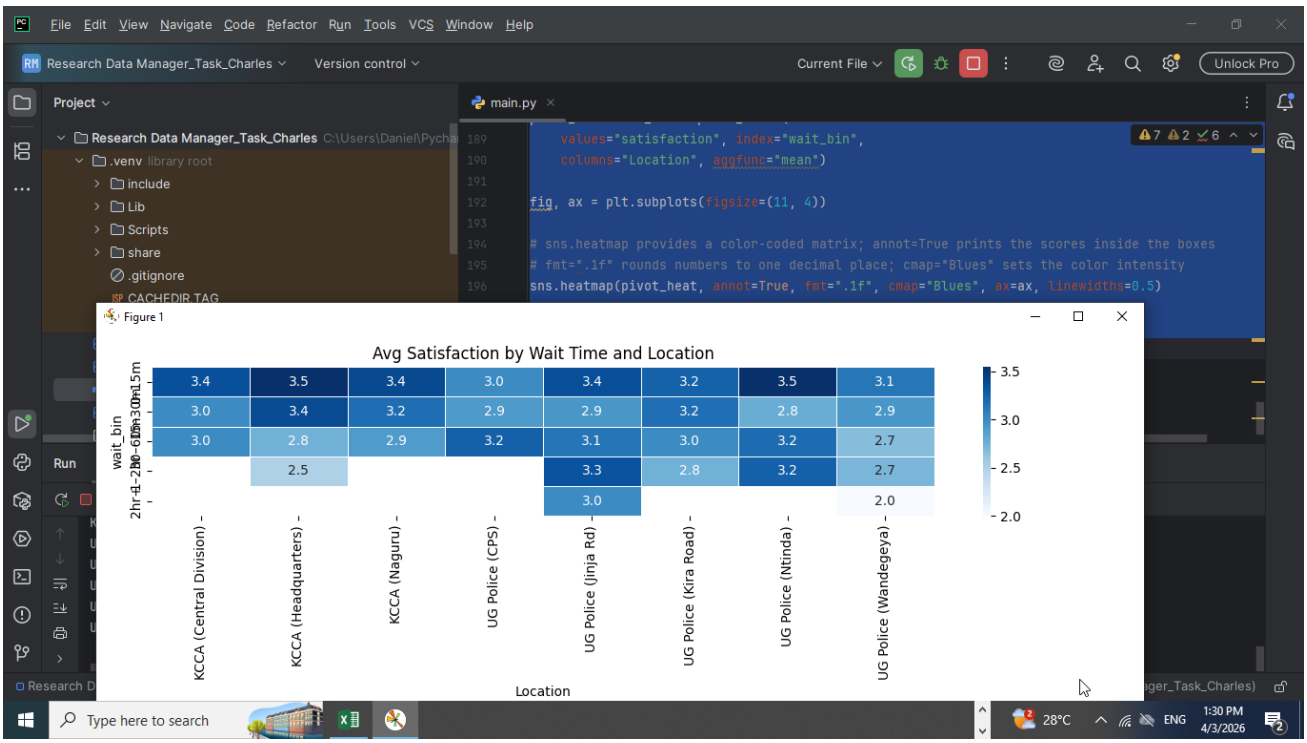
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Lib
Scripts
share
.gitignore
CACHEDIR.TAG
values="satisfaction", index="wait_bin",
columns="Location", aggfunc="mean")
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(11, 4))
# sns.heatmap provides a color-coded matrix; annot=True prints the scores inside the boxes
# fmt=".1f" rounds numbers to one decimal place; cmap="Blues" sets the color intensity
sns.heatmap(pivot_heat, annot=True, fmt=".1f", cmap="Blues", ax=ax, linewidths=0.5)
Figure 1
Avg Satisfaction by Wait Time and Location
wait_bin
2hr-1-2hr
30-60m
15-30m
0-15m
KCCA (Central Division)
KCCA (Headquarters)
KCCA (Naguru)
UG Police (CPS)
UG Police (Jinja Rd)
UG Police (Kira Road)
UG Police (Ntinda)
UG Police (Wandegeya)
Location
3.4 3.5 3.4 3.0 3.4 3.2 3.5 3.1
3.0 3.4 3.2 2.9 2.9 3.2 2.8 2.9
3.0 2.8 2.9 3.2 3.1 3.0 3.2 2.7
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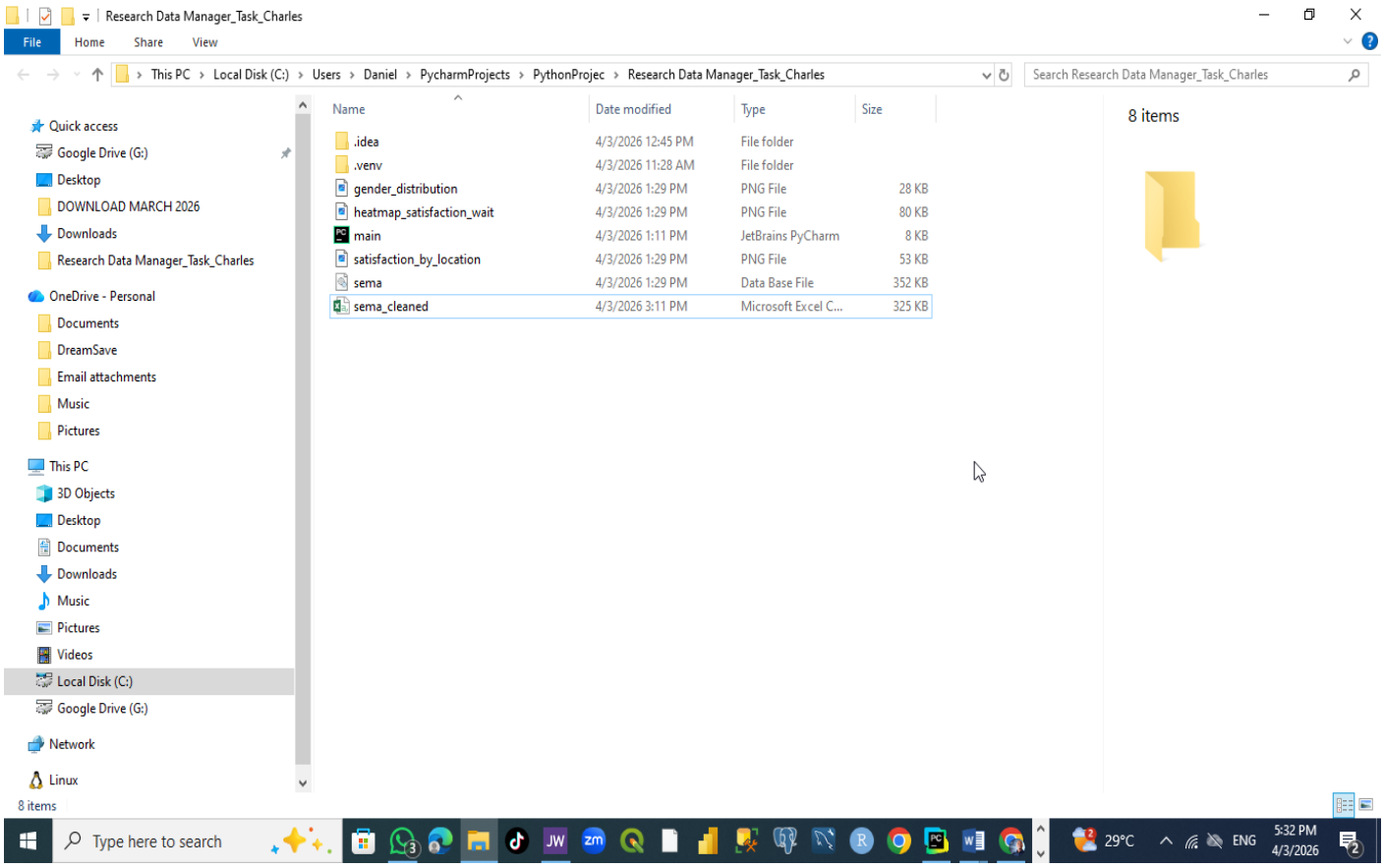
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Google Drive (G:)
Desktop
DOWNLOAD MARCH 2026
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OneDrive - Personal
Documents
DreamSave
Email attachments
Music
Pictures
This PC
3D Objects
Desktop
Documents
Downloads
Music
Pictures
Videos
Local Disk (C:)
Google Drive (G:)
Network
Linux
Name
Date modified
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